

The Necromancer

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Version: Beta v1.1

Date: 2026-02-14

Engine: Godot 4.6

Positioning: A Third Age tactical roguelike in the Sil-Q lineage, rebuilt for modern readability while preserving permadeath rigor.

1. Design Intent

The Necromancer is built around one uncompromising loop: **delve, recover, escape**.

The player enters Dol Guldur, descends under escalating pressure, secures **Thrain's map and key**, then ascends to escape.

Core design law: - decisions must remain meaningful under stress, - information must be incomplete but legible, - failure must be teachable, - victory must be earned, not accumulated.

2. Pillars

1. **Tolkien Fidelity** Language, threats, and stakes are anchored to the Third Age and written with literary restraint.
2. **Sil-Q Mechanical DNA** Tactical positioning, high-lethality exchanges, and pressure-based resource play remain central.
3. **Agency Under Constraint** At least one strategically valid alternative should exist in most dangerous turns.
4. **Readable Systems** Complexity is welcome; opacity is not. UI/logs must let players reason about outcomes.
5. **Permadeath Integrity** Losses stand. Mastery is learned through iteration.

3. Core Run Structure

1. Character setup (race, house, trait, stats).
2. Early-floor stabilization (weapon line, defense line, light line).
3. Mid-depth specialization (skills and abilities with explicit tradeoffs).
4. Objective acquisition (Thrain's map and key).
5. Ascent phase under accumulated pressure.
6. Escape or death.

4. Beta v1.1 Win State

Beta v1.1 uses a practical completion gate: - Upstairs on floor 1 checks objective state. - Escape is allowed only if the player has **Thrain's map and key**. - Success triggers: "Congratulations, you escaped! Now to meet Gandalf..." - Player returns to menu.

This is intentionally a beta endpoint before a full exterior chapter is shipped.

5. Action Economy Policy

Turn cost must track impact.

- Movement and attacks consume full turns.
- Non-transformative setup/stance/utility actions should generally be **minor actions**.
- This includes cases like parry prep, mark-like setup, and circular guard style activation unless balance demands exception.

Rationale: active tactical play should not be structurally weaker than passive play.

6. Economy Design

6.1 Light Economy

Target behavior: - darkness creates pressure and uncertainty, - depth remains tactically playable, - players can plan around light rather than lose to arbitrary blindness.

Beta v1.1 anchors: - Torch: +2 - Lantern: +3 - Elvish Light: +2, infinite - Mallorn Torch: +3 - Jeweled/Feanorian Lamp: +4, infinite - Light of the Eldar aura: +2

6.2 Voice Economy

Voice should feel scarce, powerful, and build-defining.

Beta direction: - reduce exploit loops from sustained effects, - increase opportunity cost of sustain states, - preserve viability of lore-forward runs.

6.3 Utility and Consumables

If an item is prepared for utility use, activation path should be fast and reliable in combat context. Inventory micromanagement should not be the dominant difficulty.

7. Combat, Stealth, and Information

7.1 Combat Identity

- positional advantage over raw stat inflation,
- high lethality with recoverable tactical errors,
- encounter triage as expected skill.

7.2 Stealth Role

Stealth is a primary survival language: - controls engagement order, - reduces chain pulls, - enables objective-focused routing.

7.3 Information Surfaces

Player must be able to read: - immediate threat pressure, - status burden (including poison decay expectations), - actionable options without menu friction.

8. UI and Presentation Requirements

1. **Scale and framing:** default startup should cleanly frame full playfield / HUD on common desktop resolutions, notably 1920x1080 behavior.
2. **HUD integrity:** core widgets (health, voice / mana analogs, XP gem, inventory and hotbar clusters) must retain intentional layout hierarchy.
3. **Death screen:** centered and legible; post-run analysis utility is part of design quality.

4. **Title screen:** poetic quest framing in thematic register.

9. Audio Direction

Audio priorities: - gameplay readability first, - atmosphere second, - avoid repetitive/grating cues, - maintain clear event-to-sound mapping.

10. Scope Boundaries (Beta v1.1)

In scope: - complete beta run loop with gated escape, - stable build identities, - functioning light/voice/utility systems, - coherent docs for internal playtest.

Out of scope for this milestone: - full post-escape exterior campaign, - final narrative epilogues, - final long-term balance lock.

11. Validation Gates

Release candidate must pass: 1. build and launch reliability, 2. no critical UI break in core HUD flow, 3. escape gate correctness (Thrain's map + key), 4. no known blocking activation bug for intended utility items, 5. manual smoke pass on light/voice/action economy behavior, 6. docs in sync: GDD + Tutorial + Player's Guide.

12. Risks and Mitigations

- **Over-oppression drift** (darkness/resource pressure too severe): depth-band telemetry and targeted tuning.
- **Action tax regression** (active play punished): automated/targeted audit on turn consumption for non-attack utility actions.
- **UI trust erosion** (mispositioned HUD, unclear status): prioritize high-visibility UI fixes before feature additions.
- **Doc drift** (game and guide diverge): docs update in same release branch as balance/UX changes.

13. Canonical Documentation Set

- docs/GAME_DESIGN_DOCUMENT_BETA_V1_1.md

- docs/GAME_OVERVIEW_2_PAGER_BETA_V1_1.md
- docs/manual/THE_NECROMANCER_PLAYERS_GUIDE_BETA_V1_1.md
- tutorial.md